

Helen Calder

Integrative counselling and psychotherapy for adults · Didsbury and online

PREPARED BY

Alexander Watson Studio

STAGE

Before website design

STATUS

For your review

DATE

September 2026

The direction of the website is decided here.

A Practice Clarity Blueprint sets the strategic and creative direction for your practice before any design work begins: how the practice is described, who the website should speak to most directly, how it should sound, and how it should look. Once it is agreed, the design stage builds on these decisions instead of reopening them.

Read it as a description of your practice that you are entitled to correct. Where something is factually wrong, correct it. Where the wording is right but not yours, say so as well — that is an equally useful correction.

HOW TO READ IT

- **Established.** Facts and positions already set down in your own written material. Nothing factual has been assumed; anything not yet established is listed below rather than filled in.
- **Interpretation.** Our reading of what your repeated choices mean. Most of this document is interpretation, and correcting it is the main purpose of your review.
- **Recommendation.** Proposals for the identity and the website, including several places where we think the present material should change. Approve, adjust or refuse them.

Each page is marked at the top right: the first six sections set out our understanding of the practice, the next six turn it into creative recommendations. A line at the foot of each page names what it was drawn from.

UNDERSTANDING THE PRACTICE

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A practice organised around a restraint.

THE PRACTITIONER

An integrative counsellor and psychotherapist of twelve years, person-centred at the foundation. Didsbury and online. Active in the room, not quiet in it.

THE PEOPLE

Individual adults of twenty-five and over who are managing, and have been managing for some time. Your writing addresses someone who can describe the situation and not yet say what is wrong with it.

THE CENTRAL CONCERN

Rarely a crisis. Something that has been going on for a while, and a way of coping that has quietly stopped working as well as it did.

THE FEELING TO CREATE

Being properly attended to without being taken over. Someone thinking alongside you, with the decision left exactly where it was.

Making sense of it is the work itself, not something to finish beforehand.

FROM THE PRACTICE’S OWN WORDS

It removes an entry requirement — that you arrive able to explain yourself — which your reader is unlikely to be able to meet. We would build the homepage around it.

THE PRACTICAL FACTS

FEE	£65 per 50-minute session, in person or online
REDUCED FEE	£45 — a small number of places, no means testing
SESSION LENGTH	50 minutes, weekly, at the same time
FIRST CONVERSATION	Free, about 15 minutes, telephone or video
WHO YOU WORK WITH	Individual adults, aged 25 and over
WHERE	Didsbury Village, M20, and online across the UK

Says what she notices. Stops before the conclusion.

Contributes, rather than reflects

You ask, you notice, and you say the thing that has not been said — including when what someone is saying and how they are saying it do not match. Listening is the foundation. It is not the offer.

Steady, not soothing

Calm and fairly direct, in your own description. Silences are not filled quickly — your account is that something usually arrives in them. Sessions can be uncomfortable, and the site says so rather than promising otherwise.

Correctable on purpose

“If I get it wrong, tell me. Being corrected is part of my job.”
Unusual, and load-bearing: it turns an observation into something a client is invited to refuse, so it arrives as a proposal rather than a reading applied from outside.

Practical to the width of the doorway

Fee, reduced fee, cancellation terms, reply times, the waiting list, the shallow step and 76cm. Volunteered before anyone has to ask, and written as content rather than as terms.

Refuses more than she promises

Two dozen sentences beginning *I do not, I will not, I cannot*. No diagnosis, no reports, no couples, no outcomes, no homework unless it was agreed. In this practice the refusals are part of what makes the offer legible.

Twelve years, mentioned once

Experience appears as attention accumulated, not as standing — *twelve years of paying close attention to how people talk about their lives*. State it once, explain it, then leave it alone.

A therapist who will say the awkward thing, and then leave the conclusion where it belongs.

IDENTITY STATEMENT

We have deliberately not written *warm, empathetic, non-judgemental*. Your writing demonstrates a manner rather than claiming one, and we would keep it that way.

THE REFUSALS, AS THE SITE STATES THEM No diagnosis · no prescribing · no reports, assessments or letters for courts, employers, insurers or immigration · no couples or family work · nobody under twenty-five · no homework unless it has been agreed · no telling you what to do about your marriage or your job · no promise of outcome · no card payments at the door · no organisational or EAP contracts

Taken together these are not caveats. They are the shape of the offer, and the website should present them at full size rather than tucked into an FAQ.

You are the authority. That is not a reason to say nothing.

Our reading of the position your writing takes. It decides what the website is organised around, so it is worth disagreeing with if we have it wrong.

Person-centred practice holds that the client is the authority on their own life. That is sometimes taken to mean the therapist should mainly reflect and hold back. Your writing takes it differently: because the authority stays with the client, you are freer to contribute — to ask, to notice, to say the thing that has not been said — since none of it is offered as a verdict.

So the restraint is not silence. It is that what you offer can be refused, and that the client has been told so before they need it. Your observations stay proposals rather than verdicts because the person is explicitly invited to disagree with them.

That is one belief, and most of what the practice does follows from it — including our recommendation that the website be built around the shape of a contribution rather than a list of what you treat.

There is no technique being applied to you from a distance, and no assumption that I understand your life better than you do.

DEFINING BELIEF, IN YOUR OWN WORDS

WHAT FOLLOWS FROM IT

- You may notice a pattern, or a gap between what someone says and how they say it, that becomes useful once it is put into the conversation. Saying so is the work rather than a technique applied to it.
- An observation that cannot be refused stops being an offer. So the invitation to correct you is published rather than left to be discovered.
- Understanding is the work rather than its precondition, and our recommendation is that nothing on the site implies otherwise.
- The arrangement itself stays examinable: reviews every few months, endings given notice, fees reviewed on a stated date. Deliberate rather than accidental.
- Discomfort is not in itself evidence that therapy is working — but a difficult conversation is not avoided either, and neither claim is oversold.
- You treat being the wrong therapist as information rather than as a failure, and say so early. That is consistent with the rest, and worth keeping visible.

Capable in public, and tired of how much it takes.

Who the website should speak to most directly — a question of emphasis in the writing, not a limit on who you see.

VISIBLE FROM OUTSIDE

A life that broadly works. In your own description: over-preparing, over-checking, saying yes when they meant no. Often the person holding a good deal together, which from outside can look like needing nothing.

HAPPENING INSIDE

The day run again at four in the morning. Ordinary tasks costing more than they should. Things that used to matter having gone quietly flat.

WHAT MADE IT THINKABLE NOW

Often no single thing. Your writing puts it as ways of managing that used to work having stopped working as well. Where there is an event it belongs as readily to later life as to mid-life: a bereavement, a retirement, an adult child stepping away.

WHAT THEY HOPE FOR

Somewhere to think out loud with someone who will actually respond. Not advice, and not a programme — an active therapist who does not become a directive one.

TWO THINGS THAT STOP THEM WRITING

Not being able to name it. Your writing describes someone who has been considering therapy for a long time without quite making contact, because they cannot say in a sentence what is wrong. It is the objection you answer more often than any other, and it should keep answering it.

Not knowing what they would be getting. Your writing pre-empts two things at once: a therapist who arrives with a method, and one who only mirrors. Our reading is that this reader wants a response rather than direction, which is why *I will say what I notice* reads as a reason to make contact rather than a risk in doing so.

On the age band. The site sets a floor of twenty-five, then describes a wide span: retirement, caring for a parent, grief arriving years afterwards. Our reading is that the emphasis falls on outward functioning and accumulated life rather than on any decade, occupation or income. Recommendation: state the floor, let the situations do the rest, and add no upper description.

This is where the practice separates from a competent generalist. Almost any site can say it sees anxious adults. Few of them say what the therapist will actually do once someone arrives.

The message is three beats, not a line.

PRIMARY MESSAGE

Room to think, and someone to think it through with.

I will ask questions. I will say what I notice, including when it is awkward. I will not pretend to know what you should do.

If I get it wrong, tell me.

Your existing headline is right, and half-finished on its own. *Room to think* is a claim many practices make; *someone to think it through with* is the part that belongs to you, and the beat beneath it is what makes it specific. Recommendation: the headline never appears without that second beat — in the hero, in search results, on correspondence, anywhere.

SUPPORTING MESSAGES, IN ORDER

- You do not have to work it out before you make contact.
- Nothing is being applied to you from a distance.
- The practical facts are here before you ask for them.
- If I am not the right person, I will say so, and point you somewhere more useful.

HOW IT SHOULD SOUND

Short declaratives where there is uncertainty; longer sentences only when method is being explained. Numbers stated without ceremony. The first person used openly. The second person used for what the reader *does* — get in touch, tell me, ask — and almost never for what the reader feels.

Dryness where another practice would reach for warmth: *sometimes*, as a complete answer to whether there is a waiting list. Humour appears once, is about the cello, and is at your own expense rather than the subject’s. Warm, in your own phrase, without being soft about it.

EMBRACE

- Refusals stated plainly, in the body of the page
- Numbers, including the awkward ones
- Questions you would actually ask in a session
- Sentences the reader is invited to contradict
- Ordinary language in place of clinical terms

AVOID

- Journey, safe space, holding space
- “You deserve”, “it takes courage”
- Promises of outcome, or of feeling better
- Sustained second person naming the reader’s feelings
- Any sentence that concludes on the reader’s behalf

Enough to decide by, before you speak to anyone.

FEEL	UNDERSTAND	TRUST	DO NEXT
Taken seriously without being described. Able to think without being steered, and not required to have an answer ready. The page should read as though an adult wrote it for another adult.	Within seconds: who you are, what integrative actually means, what you do in a session and what you will not do, how long it lasts, what it costs, where it happens, and that the first step is free.	Built by publication rather than assertion. The fee, the reduced fee, the cancellation terms, the limits of confidentiality, the waiting list, the referral onwards — and the standing invitation to correct you.	Arrange the free fifteen minutes without treating it as a commitment. A sentence or two is enough to send, and the telephone should be as easy as the form.

THE ARC

Arrival	Recognition	Understanding	Contact
The claim, then the beat that qualifies it, then the facts, so the practical questions are answered before anything is asked of them.	Situations described without an owner, so a reader can recognise themselves without being told what they feel.	What you contribute, in ordinary words — and, in the same breath, what you will not.	A short form that says a sentence or two is plenty, and a page that says exactly what happens after it is sent.

STATED IN YOUR OWN VOICE, AS CONTENT RATHER THAN AS SMALL PRINT · 48 hours’ notice or the session is charged · a reply within two working days, and nothing at weekends · one shallow step, a 76cm doorway and a toilet that is not accessible · sometimes there is a waiting list · what this practice cannot serve, with plain crisis signposting

Contribution without verdict.

One governing idea, and it is not a metaphor for the practice — it is the practice, laid out. The reader’s material holds the page: wider, first in reading order, and the default everywhere. Your contribution enters beside it, narrower, beginning lower than the thing it answers, in one colour, and measured by a rule that shows exactly how far it extends. Then the ground takes the last word back.

The third beat is what stops this being a two-column layout: the page ends by handing back.

Authority comes from the precision of the contribution; warmth from the fact that it never takes over. Space does the work decoration usually does — what is left around your words is the measure of how much room the reader keeps.

She never starts at the top of what she answers.

DESIGN PRINCIPLE

In plain terms: your words begin a little below the paragraph they answer, so they read as a response rather than an introduction.

WHAT IT CARRIES

- Two voices, kept visibly apart
- A third beat that returns the last word
- One colour, with one meaning
- Facts in the reader’s voice, not the practitioner’s
- Exactness in every number and measure
- Warmth carried by the writing, not the styling

WHAT IT AVOIDS

- Sage, blush, gradients, soft shadows
- Circles, arcs and paths as “connection”
- Botanical motifs and decorative line art
- Script and handwritten type
- Photography of calm
- Anything that makes attentiveness look passive

One caution. The pattern is strong enough to become a tic. It belongs where you genuinely add something and nowhere else: applied uniformly it turns a clinical stance into a house style, which is the opposite of what it is for.

A wordmark, and two bars that never level up.

The identity is the wordmark. We are not recommending a mark in the site header: the layout already carries the idea at full size, and a badge of it above the page would only repeat it.

The device exists for the places a wordmark cannot go. Two bars — the ground, and the contribution, which begins lower, runs shorter, and finishes level with it. One relationship, drawn once, legible at thirty-two pixels.

CONSTRUCTION

- The contribution bar is 70% of the ground bar and sits on the same baseline
- They never align at the top, and never sit on unequal baselines
- Clear space of one bar height on all four sides; minimum 16px, and below that the ground bar alone
- Never outlined, rotated, enclosed, or set on a photograph

What is being agreed here is the relationship. Exact ratios, clear-space values and file variants are carried into the build.

PROHIBITED The contribution bar drawn equal to or taller than the ground · the two centred on one another, or the contribution arriving first · the device used as a bullet, divider or watermark · the wordmark set in the sans · the descriptor set in anything but the serif, in ash

PRIMARY WORDMARK

Helen Calder

COUNSELLING & PSYCHOTHERAPY

Site header, footer, correspondence. Source Serif 4 Semibold, tracking -0.012em ; descriptor in the same serif, never in the sans.

DEVICE · FAVICON AND APP ICON



Shown at 64, 32 and 16 pixels. The offset must survive at every size.

LOCKUP · CORRESPONDENCE

Helen Calder
COUNSELLING & PSYCHOTHERAPY

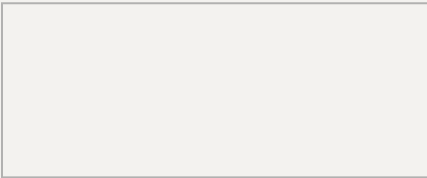
Letterhead and email signature only. The bars sit to the left, baseline-aligned to the descriptor.

ON SLATE · SINGLE COLOUR



The blue lifts to #A9B6EE on dark grounds. Where one colour only is possible, both bars take it and the offset does the work.

Four jobs. One of them coloured.

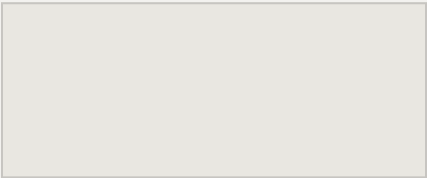


Paper

#F3F2EF

THE GROUND

The reading surface, and most of what a visitor sees. A warm off-white with the yellow taken out of it.



Shelf

#E9E7E1

STRUCTURE

Alternating bands, so a long page can be scanned. It separates sections and means nothing else. Never a card, never a box.

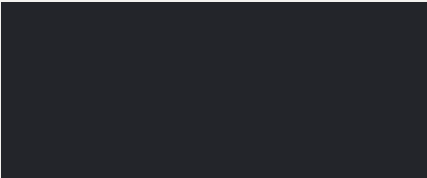


Ink and Ash

#1B1D1F

THE READING VOICE

All ground type, including every practical fact. Ash is the same voice at label weight: section labels, captions and hints.



Slate

#23252A

THE DEEP FIELD

Footer, studio strip, and the two pages of this document that state a position. Structural, never expressive — a dark that is neither black nor navy.



Contribution

#28356B

HELEN ENTERING

Your words, the rule that measures them, and the one action the page offers. Nowhere else. On slate it lifts to #A9B6EE, holding the same weight.

PROPORTION ON ANY SCREEN



Paper 69 Shelf 17 Slate 9.4 Contribution 3.4 Ash 1.2

Contrast, every pairing measured: ink on paper 15.1:1 · ink on shelf 13.7:1 · paper on slate 13.7:1 · white on contribution 11.6:1 · contribution on paper 10.4:1 · contribution on shelf 9.4:1 · contribution light on slate 7.8:1 · ash on paper 6.4:1 · ash on shelf 5.8:1. The lowest pairing anywhere is 5.8:1, at label size; the lifted blue on slate holds 7.8:1 at its smallest use.

One correction. The blue also marks the Contact link in the navigation — a fourth use of a colour meant to have one. Take it out of the navigation; the action in the page already does that job.

One family. Two people in it.

SOURCE SERIF 4 · THE GROUND

Aa Helen Calder

Everything the reader reads: headings, prose, navigation, the wordmark, and *every practical fact*. The fee, the fifty minutes and the 76cm sit in the ground voice because they belong to the reader — they are what someone needs in order to decide. This is where the system parts company with most two-typeface schemes.

HIERARCHY

DISPLAY	Serif Medium, 37–66px	Room to think.
HEADING	Serif Medium, 24–34px	What “integrative” means
BODY	Serif Regular, 17–19px	You are the authority on your own life.
CONTRIBUTION	Sans Medium, 1.02× body	I will ask questions.
LABEL	Serif Semibold, 13px, .135em	HOW I WORK
FIGURES	Serif, tabular, in the ground	£65 · 50 minutes · 48 hours · 76cm

Measure. Ground 35.5rem, about 57 characters; contribution 19.5rem, about 38 — narrower, so it can never outweigh what it answers.

SOURCE SANS 3 · THE CONTRIBUTION

I will say what I notice.

Your contributions and nothing else — at the same optical size as the ground it answers, one weight heavier, on a shorter measure, so it reads as an equal rather than as a heading over it. Three places only: what you contribute, the one action, and the message the form returns.

THE RULE

The sans is not “facts”. The sans is Helen. Nothing enters it because it is short, practical or important; it enters because you are the one saying it. Applied consistently, a reader learns the difference without being told it.

MOBILE

Below 56rem the pair becomes one column in the same order — ground, contribution, open — keeping its rule, its colour and its shorter measure. A reading order that becomes a layout, rather than a layout that has to degrade.

NOT USED

- A third family, anywhere
- Italic for emphasis — position does that job
- Letterspaced or all-capital serif at reading size
- The sans for navigation, labels, headings or figures
- More than two heading sizes on one page

Three photographs, each answering a question.

The site is typographic and should stay that way. Photography enters only where a page makes a claim the reader cannot otherwise check — three places, not none.

The argument for a portrait follows from your own copy: the site asks a reader to judge whether they could sit in a silence with you, be told something awkward, and correct you. That is a judgement about a person, and at present nothing on the site lets them begin it. The free fifteen minutes is where it is actually made; our recommendation is that a photograph makes it easier to ask for.

LIGHT AND TREATMENT

Daylight from one direction, with visible shadow. Nothing lit to look warm. Slightly desaturated; no grade towards cream or sage. Square corners, full column, never behind text, never overlaid, and each appears once.

THE BRIEF

- 01

The portrait. About Helen only. Daylight, eye level, ordinary conversational distance, looking at the camera. Not on the homepage: the homepage asks a reader to judge the arrangement, About is where they are judging the person.
- 02

The door. Contact. The entrance as someone arrives at it, showing the shallow step and the handrail. The access paragraph makes precise claims; a photograph is the quickest way for someone to judge them for themselves.
- 03

The room. Contact, or How I work. The consulting room from the doorway, as a first visitor sees it, chairs where they actually are and nothing tidied out of shot.

A fourth photograph — Didsbury, atmospherically — was considered and refused. The place claims this practice makes are practical: a tram stop, two hours’ parking, one step. A view of the village answers none of them, and would be the first decorative thing on the site.

NOT PHOTOGRAPHED Hands holding mugs · empty chairs · tissue boxes and candles · plants as emotional shorthand · anything staged to resemble a session · you mid-gesture or mid-laugh · stock images of calm · the room lit to look like an interiors feature

What follows for the website.

Each requirement follows from a conclusion on an earlier page. If a conclusion changes when you review it, the requirement beside it changes with it.

STRATEGIC CONCLUSION	DESIGN REQUIREMENT
Authority stays with the reader; the contribution enters, and then stops.	The pair, in three beats. Ground — the reader’s material, wider, first in reading order. Contribution — narrower, entering 2.15rem lower, in the one colour, with a rule that measures how far it extends. Open — back in the ground voice, taking the last word.
The objection answered most often is “I cannot say what is wrong.”	Answered once in the hero pair and once beside the action, never as a paragraph of reassurance. The form asks for “a sentence or two” and gives the telephone equal prominence.
Contribution styling marks what you say, and nothing else.	The sans is used only for words you would genuinely say to someone in the room. Copy in which the site describes itself — “they are not a checklist”, “not a menu” — belongs in the ground voice.
A list of situations is not a place where you add anything.	Situations are written in the ground voice, unpaired, as the homepage list already does. A long run of paired items flattens the pattern that carries the whole idea.
Practical facts belong to the reader before they belong to the practice.	Fee, reduced fee, session length, first conversation, who you work with and availability in the first screen, in the ground voice, in plain numerals — not in the contribution and not in small print.
Trust is earned by volunteering the awkward fact.	Cancellation terms, reply times, the waiting list, the limits of confidentiality, what you do not offer, and 76cm — written as content, at full size. Each stated once and linked onwards, so repetition does not spend the effect.
There is one action, and it is a conversation rather than a booking.	“Arrange a free 15-minute conversation”, in the contribution colour, once per screenful at most, with the telephone number beside it. No booking widget, no “Book now”, no second competing action.
Nothing here concludes on the reader’s behalf.	No testimonials, no outcome claims, no quiz, no mailing list, no condition checklist a reader has to fit. The five-stage account of the arrangement stays, because it is what makes the arrangement examinable — and the 404 page keeps the pair, because the pattern is the practice, not a homepage device.

The whole direction, on one page.

PROFESSIONAL IDENTITY

An integrative counsellor who contributes — questions, observations, the awkward noticing — and stops short of the conclusion, because the conclusion belongs to the client.

PHILOSOPHY

The client is the authority, which is what leaves you free to contribute. Your observations stay proposals rather than verdicts, because the person is invited to disagree with them.

VOICE

Calm, plain and fairly direct. Warm, in your own phrase, without being soft about it. Refuses more than it promises, and states its numbers without ceremony.

IDENTITY IDEA

Contribution without verdict — ground, contribution, and the last word returning to the reader. A wordmark; two bars that never level up.

VISUAL DIRECTION

Paper and slate, and one blue with one meaning. Source Serif 4 for the ground including every fact; Source Sans 3 for the contribution alone. Three photographs. Wide margins, hairline rules, no ornament.

PEOPLE TO REACH

Adults of twenty-five and over whose lives broadly work and are costing more effort than they did, who cannot yet say in a sentence what is wrong, and who want a therapist who will respond rather than only reflect.

CORE MESSAGE

Room to think, and someone to think it through with.

Never printed without the beat that follows it.

DESIRED FEELING

Properly attended to, and still in charge of it.

WEBSITE PRIORITY

Let a reader see you contributing — asking, noticing, stopping short — before they decide whether to speak to you.

THE ONE TEST

Nothing on the page may close a question that Helen would leave open.

It rules out testimonials, outcome claims, quizzes and client categories, and it is the reason the third beat exists.

Does this sound like your practice?

Once you approve it, this Blueprint is the agreed direction for the website. The build then works from these pages, so the time goes into making the site good instead of settling the same questions twice. Clarity now is what removes the guesswork later.

Read it once quickly and once slowly. Where something is factually wrong, correct it. Where something is right but badly put, say so — that is an equally useful correction. Where you disagree with a recommendation, say what you would want instead, or simply say it is not you, and we will find the version that is.

Two consolidated rounds of revision are included at this stage. Sending your comments together produces a better document and a faster build.

Portfolio note — Helen Calder is a fictional practice created by Alexander Watson Studio to demonstrate the Practice Clarity Blueprint. No discovery interview took place: this Blueprint has been reconstructed from the concept website, which is the only source. The qualification, registration, insurance, supervision, consulting room, fee, availability, telephone number and email address belong to the concept alone and none is real. This note appears only in portfolio editions.

WHAT TO REVIEW

- Factual accuracy, and the details still to confirm
- Whether the description on page 04 sounds like you
- The philosophy on page 05 — the one judgement everything else rests on
- The governing idea on page 09: contribution without verdict
- Who the site should speak to most directly
- The message, and the voice
- The wordmark, and the device
- Colour and typography
- Photography, and what you are willing to be photographed doing
- The three changes to copy already written, on page 14
- The one test on page 15

AFTER APPROVAL

Design begins from the direction agreed here, so the website can concentrate on bringing it to life instead of reopening the same decisions.



Helen Calder

COUNSELLING & PSYCHOTHERAPY

Prepared by Alexander Watson Studio · alexanderwatson.co.uk